HOUSE RULES

These are the places our table departs from the **Five Torches Deep** rulebook. Everything not listed here plays **as written**. Full tables for ailments and Wisdom of Age boons are in **Veterans & Ailments**.

Veteran Heroes

Official FTD: Start at level 1, earn XP, and level up to the cap of 9.

House rule: Start at **level 9**. There is **no XP** and no leveling. Characters change through story instead: new legends, upgrades to Old Faithful, and the optional **worsening** rule.

Quick Build

1. Roll ability scores (below), arrange them, add racial boosts.
2. Pick class, race and archetype.
3. HP: maximum at level 1, then the class die's average for levels 2–9.
4. Apply every level-up gain through level 9.
5. Add the four veteran traits and two ailments.

Ability Scores

Official FTD: Humans roll 3d6 in order and swap two. Other races get two fixed 13s and roll 2d6+3 for the rest.

House rule: Everyone rolls **4d6, drop the lowest**, six times, and places the results in any order. Then add racial boosts. Class minimums (13+) are checked **after** boosts.

Race	Boosts
Human	+2 to two different abilities of your choice
Dwarf	+2 CON, +2 STR
Elf	+2 DEX, +2 INT
Halfling	+2 WIS, +2 CHA

Modifiers Past 18

Official FTD: An 18 or higher is +4.

House rule: Modifiers keep climbing.

Score	Modifier
18–19	+4
20–21	+5
22–23	+6

Racial Traits

Official FTD: Races have no abilities of their own.

House rule: Dwarves, **elves** and **halflings** each pick **2 traits** from their race's list. Humans get none.

Race	Trait	Effect
Dwarf	Darksight	See in darkness to 60 ft as if dim light.
Dwarf	Dwarven Resilience	Advantage vs poison; poison damage halved.
Dwarf	Stonecunning	Advantage on stonework, mining and underground direction. Can't get lost underground.
Dwarf	Dwarven Toughness	+1 HP per level (+9 at level 9).
Dwarf	Armor-Bred	Heavy armor: no disadvantage on stamina checks; counts as 4 load.
Dwarf	Axe & Hammer	Proficient with hatchet, war axe, warhammer, lumber axe.
Elf	Darksight	See in darkness to 60 ft as if dim light.
Elf	Keen Senses	Advantage on sight and listening checks.
Elf	Fey Ancestry	Advantage vs charm; magic can't put you to sleep.
Elf	Trance	Four hours of trance gives a full night's rest.
Elf	Elven Weapons	Proficient with arming sword, longsword, hunting and war bows.
Elf	Elven Cantrip	One arcane cantrip, cast with INT and no check.
Halfling	Lucky	Reroll a natural 1 on a d20 check once.
Halfling	Brave	Advantage vs fear.
Halfling	Nimble	Move through larger creatures' spaces; advantage to escape grapples.
Halfling	Naturally Stealthy	Hide behind a larger creature, with advantage.
Halfling	Stout Resilience	Advantage vs poison; poison damage halved.
Halfling	Sure Shot	+1 to attack with thrown weapons, slings, hunting bows.

Veteran Traits

Every PC takes all four.

Old Faithful. Your signature and reasonably mythic magic item from your glory days. Name it and describe its properties, then agree them with your GM. It is never lost or broken unless you choose a dramatic moment for it.

Legend. Write one line: the deed you are remembered for. Once per session, invoke it for **advantage** on one social check. The GM may have someone recognize you at the worst moment, too.

Broke. You start with **no coin**. Say where all your gold went.

Rust. Every class ability starts **rusty**. Using one needs a **DC 12 check** with its closest ability score. Fail and it doesn't work, or only partly works (GM's call). One success clears the flag.

Wisdom of Age. Pick one boon at creation from the Battle-Wise, Road-Wise, Worldly, Hard-Won Knowledge or Grit & Spirit lists.

Magic Items

Official FTD: The number of magic items a PC can use is limited by CHA modifier.
House rule: There is **no limit**.

Retainers

Official FTD: Maximum followers is set by CHA score.
House rule: Maximum followers equals your **CHA modifier** (0 if it is 0 or less). At level 9 every one is a **hench**: 3 HD, loyal, no wages. Roll 1d4 for each one's type; reroll freely at creation. Names can wait until play.

d4	Type
1	**Laborer.** Hauling, digging, camp work.
2	**Expert.** Guides, scribes, smiths, lore.
3	**Militia.** Spears, shields, holding the line.
4	**Adept.** Minor rites, wards, potions.

Ailments

Each PC takes **two ailments**: roll d100 twice or pick two. An ailment applies only when its **trigger** happens; there are no standing penalties.

Flare-up. Once per session per PC, the GM may invoke an ailment outside its trigger when the fiction supports it. The player can refuse by paying a Grit token.

Grit. Gain a token when an ailment complicates a scene, or when you bring your ailment in unprompted and it costs you. Spend one to **reroll** any d20 you just rolled, add **1d6** to an ally's check as you bark advice, or **refuse a flare-up**. Hold a maximum of 2. Tokens don't carry between sessions.

Worsening (optional). After a near-death moment, the GM may offer a third ailment in exchange for +1 to an ability score of the player's choice.

Remedies. In downtime, pay **25 gp** for a tonic, brace, spectacles or ear trumpet. One chosen ailment is suppressed until the end of the next adventure. The remedy can break once, at the GM's call, during a dramatic moment.

> Old Brann has **Bad Knee**. Chasing a thief up a ladder, the trigger fires: his climb check is at disadvantage. He fails, and the GM hands him a Grit token. Two rounds later he spends it to reroll a missed attack against the thief.

Spellcasting

Official FTD: d20 + casting mod + proficiency vs **DC = 10 + spell's level**. Failure triggers a mishap and locks out that spell level until a safe rest.
House rule: Kept as written, lockout included. At level 9, proficiency (+4) keeps failure between 0% and 40%.

Failure Chance at Level 9

Failure means a mishap and lockout. It is the same for mages (INT) and zealots (WIS).

Mod	Cantrip	L1	L2	L3	L4	L5
+2	15%	20%	25%	30%	35%	40%
+3	10%	15%	20%	25%	30%	35%
+4	5%	10%	15%	20%	25%	30%
+5	0%	5%	10%	15%	20%	25%
+6	0%	0%	5%	10%	15%	20%

Cantrip column assumes cantrips need a check (DC 10). The book doesn't make a natural 1 an automatic failure.

One Roll, Two Jobs

A targeted spell uses a **single roll**. It must clear both the casting DC and the target's defense.

- Beats the DC but not the defense: the spell is cast and **misses**. No mishap, no lockout.
- Fails the DC: **mishap and lockout**, whatever the target's defense.

> A level 9 mage with INT +4 casts a level 4 spell at a troll (defense 13). She rolls d20 + 8 and gets 13. That beats the troll's defense but not DC 14, so the spell mishaps and she can't cast level 4 spells again until a safe rest.

What Stays Core FTD

The four classes and their archetypes, torches, supply (SUP), resilience, disease, fatigue and exhaustion, and the Magical Mishap Table. Monsters use FTD's 5e conversion (half HP), with numbers scaled up for a level 9 party.